

Saroj Mahapatra

Saroj Mahapatra is the ninth Executive Director of PRADAN (since April 2022), the national non-profit founded in 1983 on the idea that skilled, empathetic professionals should work alongside India's rural poor. A PRADAN professional for nearly three decades, he now leads its work with 3.4 million+ households across 10 states.

Education

- Master's degree in hydraulics and irrigation engineering

Career

Joined PRADAN in 1996, straight out of his engineering master's, and spent his early years working directly with Adivasi, Dalit and other deprived communities of Central India. Led projects orchestrating multi-stakeholder engagement in Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, and provided thematic leadership on smallholder irrigation and climate-resilient infrastructure through Integrated Natural Resource Management (INRM).

Rose to Integrator for the state of Chhattisgarh. Across 25+ years, worked on Central and State Government projects to improve the effectiveness of flagship programmes such as MGNREGA and NRLM, on multilateral projects with WFP, IFAD, UNICEF and the World Bank, and on building multi-stakeholder networks — consistently anchoring the leadership of women from the most marginalised households.

Took over as Executive Director on 1 April 2022, succeeding Narendranath Damodaran.

Policy Contributions

- Instrumental in preparing the INRM manual for MGNREGA implementation, Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India
- Member of working groups on inclusive Village Development Planning, strengthening rural livelihoods, convergence of flagship programmes, and climate-resilient interventions
- Contributor to India Development Review on rural development and organisation-building, including the urban and tech bias in India's COVID-19 response and building people-centric organisations



Saroj Mahapatra's Story

Trained in hydraulics and irrigation, Saroj's turning point came on his first visit to villages in undivided Bihar, which showed him the depth of rural poverty. He joined PRADAN in 1996 and brought an engineer's understanding of water into decades of community work.

In the field he came to see livelihoods as more than income. PRADAN's work aims at what he calls "being-level" change — the shift from "I cannot do this" to "Yes, I can." Communities map their present and desired states, and progress is built on the 5A framework: access, assets, attitude, ability and assurance.

Leadership at PRADAN

As Executive Director, Saroj leads a deliberately decentralised organisation of about 70 field teams. He leads it with rotational leadership and periodic renewal of the organisation itself, and puts learning ahead of monitoring and evaluation.

He sees people as PRADAN's core asset. The year-long Development Apprenticeship has trained 4,000+ professionals, 90% of whom remain in the development sector. PRADAN hires for intellectual, social and emotional maturity, recruiting good people first and letting funding follow.

PRADAN speaks of "graduation" rather than exit. Farmer producer organisations and India's largest smallholder poultry business now run independently, and public money is routed directly to community institutions.

His philosophy: build people, collective leadership, and institutions that outlive their founders.